Where Are the Nine?

Gratitude turns back to Jesus to give thanks; receiving God's gifts without thanking him misses the greatest blessing of all.

Main passage	Luke 17:11-19 (KJV)
Topic	Thankfulness
Audience	adults
Length	about 45 minutes
Status	Draft: written by AI from the library, not yet reviewed by Dave

Suggested timing

Opening	4 min
Scripture	3 min
Background	5 min
Teaching point 1: Ten cried for mercy and all ten were healed	7 min
Teaching point 2: Only one returned to give thanks	7 min
Teaching point 3: Thankfulness receives the greater blessing	7 min
Discussion questions	7 min
Application	3 min
Closing prayer	2 min
Total	45 min

Opening (4 min)

Ask: "When did you last write a thank-you note? Who taught you to say thank you?" Then ask: "Why is it so easy to forget?" This lesson fits well around Thanksgiving, but the lesson of the ten lepers is for every week of the year.

Scripture (3 min)

Luke 17:11-19

11 And it came to pass, as he went to Jerusalem, that he passed through the midst of Samaria and Galilee. 12 And as he entered into a certain village, there met him ten men that were lepers, which stood afar off: 13 And they lifted up their voices, and said, Jesus, Master, have mercy on us. 14 And when he saw them, he said unto them, Go shew yourselves unto the priests. And it came to pass, that, as they went, they were

cleansed. [15] And one of them, when he saw that he was healed, turned back, and with a loud voice glorified God, [16] And fell down on his face at his feet, giving him thanks: and he was a Samaritan. [17] And Jesus answering said, Were there not ten cleansed? but where are the nine? [18] There are not found that returned to give glory to God, save this stranger. [19] And he said unto him, Arise, go thy way: thy faith hath made thee whole.

Read the passage aloud. Before you read, tell the class to listen for how many were healed and how many came back.

Background (5 min)

Jesus was travelling toward Jerusalem along the border between Samaria and Galilee. Leprosy, a name used for several serious skin diseases, made a person ceremonially unclean. Lepers had to live outside towns and keep their distance from others (Leviticus 13:45-46). That is why the ten "stood afar off" and shouted.

The law of Moses required a healed leper to show himself to a priest, who would confirm the cure so the person could return to normal life (Leviticus 14). Jesus sent the ten off before they were healed, and they were cleansed "as they went." Nine kept going. One, a Samaritan, came back.

Teacher note: Jews and Samaritans did not usually mix (see John 4:9). Shared suffering had brought this group together, but it was the outsider, the Samaritan, who returned to give thanks.

Teaching point 1: Ten cried for mercy and all ten were healed (7 min)

All ten prayed, "Jesus, Master, have mercy on us." All ten obeyed by setting off for the priests. All ten were healed. Jesus' mercy was generous to every one of them, including the nine who never thanked him. God gives many good gifts to people who never acknowledge him (Matthew 5:45).

Supporting verses

Luke 17:11-14: And it came to pass, as he went to Jerusalem, that he passed through the midst of Samaria and Galilee. And as he entered into a certain village, there met him ten men that were lepers, which stood afar off: And they lifted up their voices, and said, Jesus, Master, have mercy on us. And when he saw them, he said unto them, Go shew yourselves unto the priests. And it came to pass, that, as they went, they were cleansed.

Matthew 5:45: That ye may be the children of your Father which is in heaven: for he maketh his sun to rise on the evil and on the good, and sendeth rain on the just and on the unjust.

Psalm 145:9: The LORD is good to all: and his tender mercies are over all his works.

> *"Temporal mercies are then doubled and sweetened to us when they are fetched in by the prayers of faith, and returned by the praises of faith."*
> — Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Luke 17:11-19

Handout blanks (answers)

All ten lepers cried, "Jesus, Master, have **mercy** on us."

As they went, they were **cleansed**.

Teaching point 2: Only one returned to give thanks (7 min)

"Where are the nine?" Barnes suggests they were busy doing what they had been told and eager to get on with their lives. They were not wicked, just forgetful. Ingratitude is often not rebellion but neglect. The one who came back turned around, praised God with a loud voice, and fell at Jesus' feet. Gratitude goes back to the Giver.

Supporting verses

Luke 17:15-18: And one of them, when he saw that he was healed, turned back, and with a loud voice glorified God, And fell down on his face at his feet, giving him thanks: and he was a Samaritan. And Jesus answering said, Were there not ten cleansed? but where are the nine? There are not found that returned to give glory to God, save this stranger.

Psalm 103:2: Bless the LORD, O my soul, and forget not all his benefits:

Romans 1:21: Because that, when they knew God, they glorified him not as God, neither were thankful; but became vain in their imaginations, and their foolish heart was darkened.

> *"They were impatient to be healed and selfish in wishing it, and had no gratitude to God"*
> — Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Luke 17:17

> *"This man, sensible of the power of God and grateful for his mercies, returned to express his gratitude to God for his goodness."*
> — Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Luke 17:15

Handout blanks (answers)

"Were there not ten cleansed? but where are the **nine**?"

Ingratitude is often not rebellion but **neglect (forgetfulness)**.

Teaching point 3: Thankfulness receives the greater blessing (7 min)

Jesus told the Samaritan, "Thy faith hath made thee whole." All ten were cleansed in body, but this man received something more: a personal encounter with Jesus and a word of welcome. Gratitude does not earn God's gifts; it brings us closer to the Giver. Those who seem furthest from God are sometimes the most thankful.

Supporting verses

Luke 17:19: And he said unto him, Arise, go thy way: thy faith hath made thee whole.

1 Thessalonians 5:18: In every thing give thanks: for this is the will of God in Christ Jesus concerning you.

Colossians 3:15-17: And let the peace of God rule in your hearts, to the which also ye are called in one body; and be ye thankful. Let the word of Christ dwell in you richly in all wisdom; teaching and admonishing one another in psalms and

hymns and spiritual songs, singing with grace in your hearts to the Lord. And what soever ye do in word or deed, do all in the name of the Lord Jesus, giving thanks to God and the Father by him.

> *"not as the others, merely in body, but in that higher spiritual sense"*
> — David Brown, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on Luke 17:19

> *"Often God receives more praise and affectionate obedience from those who had long lived without his knowledge and fear, than from those who were bred up among his people"*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Luke 17:18

Handout blanks (answers)

Thy faith hath made thee **whole**.

In every thing give **thanks**.

Discussion questions (7 min)

1. Why do you think the nine did not come back?

Excitement, hurry to get home, assuming thanks could wait, or simply taking the gift for granted.

2. What blessings do we most easily take for granted?

Health, family, daily provision, freedom to worship, salvation itself.

3. Why might the outsider, the Samaritan, have been the one to return?

He may have been more aware that he had no claim on Jesus' mercy. Those who know they do not deserve a gift are often most grateful.

4. How does giving thanks change the person who gives it?

It turns attention from gifts to Giver, deepens faith, guards against pride and discontent, and brings joy.

Application (3 min)

Write three thank-you notes this week: one to God (a written prayer), one to someone in your family, and one to someone at church who has blessed you. Each evening, before bed, name three things God gave you that day.

Closing prayer (2 min)

Lord Jesus, you have had mercy on us again and again. Forgive us for the times we have gone on our way without turning back to thank you. Give us grateful hearts that see your gifts and praise you for them, in good times and hard times. Thank you most of all for the gift of yourself. Amen.

Sources quoted

Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Luke 17:11-19

Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Luke 17:17

Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Luke 17:15

David Brown, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on Luke 17:19

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Luke 17:18

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